DRUGS · LOCAL ANAESTHETICS AND VASOCONSTRICTORS

Co-phenylcaine and topical nasal anaesthesia

Co-phenylcaine is a nasal spray of lidocaine 5% with phenylephrine 0.5%: an anaesthetic and a decongestant in one. It is the standard preparation for nasendoscopy, cautery of Little's area, nasal biopsy and removal of foreign bodies in the clinic, and it shrinks the mucosa to show the middle meatus and nasopharynx.

1 CHAPTER ONE At a glance

The drug on one page.

1.1 Summary

CO-PHENYLCAINE

	SUMMARY
Composition	Lidocaine hydrochloride 5% and phenylephrine hydrochloride 0.5% (each spray about 5 mg lidocaine and 0.5 mg phenylephrine)
How it works	Sodium-channel block (lidocaine) and alpha-1 vasoconstriction (phenylephrine)
ENT uses	Rigid and flexible nasendoscopy; cautery for epistaxis; biopsy; nasal foreign body removal in older children and adults; packing removal; preparation for flexible laryngoscopy (with a throat spray)
Dose	Adults and children over 12: up to 8 sprays in total (commonly 2 to 5 sprays into each nostril); children 8 to 12: up to 5 sprays; wait about 5 to 10 minutes
Avoid	Under 8 years; MAOIs within 2 weeks; severe hypertension or ischaemic heart disease (caution); hyperthyroidism

2 CHAPTER TWO Using it in ENT

Practice.

2.1 Technique

Spray with the patient's head slightly forward, aiming along the floor and toward the middle meatus; wait at least 5 minutes. Soaked cotton pledgets placed under the inferior and middle turbinates give deeper anaesthesia for cautery or biopsy. Warn the patient about the bitter taste and the numb throat, and advise nothing to eat or drink until sensation returns (about an hour) if the spray has reached the pharynx.

2.2 Alternatives

Lidocaine spray alone with xylometazoline, or for children, topical anaesthetic gel or a short examination without anaesthesia.

3 CHAPTER THREE Safety

What goes wrong.

3.1 Adverse effects

Bitter taste, numb throat, occasional palpitations and hypertension; vasovagal reactions during procedures; local anaesthetic toxicity if excess is used, especially in children.

3.2 Interactions

MAOIs, tricyclics and beta blockers (phenylephrine).

4 CHAPTER FOUR For the examination

What the examiner wants to hear.

4.1 Viva essentials

WHAT THE EXAMINER IS LOOKING FOR

- Composition and maximum sprays.
- Advice after use (numb throat, aspiration risk).

4.2 Common pitfalls

COMMON PITFALLS

- Exceeding the spray limit in a small child.

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